

Both editions, A and B, must have continued in use for a considerable time. The extent to which Edition B was used may be judged from the fact that it was the one from which the old Greek version was made, as well as the one used by Josephus in writing his history of the Jews;¹⁶ while for a witness to the prestige of Edition A we have the fact that it was ultimately taken as the basis of the recension which alone was adopted for the "official" Hebrew Bible.

It deserves especially to be emphasized that the Story of the Three Youths was present in both of the current forms of the history. At the beginning of the Christian era, there was probably no version of the Chronicler's book in existence which did not contain this Story. Certain it is, at any rate, that those who made the recension now represented by our massoretic text knew of no such form already existing, but were obliged to resort to excision.

The trouble caused in the Jewish world by this Levitical History of Israel, in its two incongruous editions, could be imagined even if we had no direct proof of it. As time went on, and the lingering traditional knowledge of the Persian period dwindled and disappeared, the Chronicler's compilation stood out conspicuously as the one document dealing with the history of the Jews in this important time. It seems to have been little used at first, and when at last it became generally known it was looked upon with suspicion (witness its position in the Jewish canon, and its rejection from the Syriac Bible, to say nothing of other indications), but its ultimate recognition was inevitable. The final test came, of course, when the idea of a definite "canon" of divinely inspired scripture was first developed; namely, about the beginning of the second century A. D. The Jewish rabbis were obliged to meet squarely the question whether they should accept this book or reject it. On the one hand, it was the source, and the indispensable support, of certain theories which had come to be implicitly believed and cherished, especially in ecclesiastical circles; but, on the other hand, it was obviously an untrustworthy guide. Anyone could see that the Story of the Three Youths was incongruous with its surroundings, and it needed no unusual acumen to see that it was in fact an interpolation. Such naïve attempts to cut the knot as that of Josephus, who substitutes

¹⁶ And Josephus, as we know, was a writer who would have been careful to employ the *orthodox* recension.